Dickson Public Schools

Parent and Family Engagement Policy

Dickson Public Schools recognizes that effective school-family partnerships are critical to student learning and success in school.

Research shows that students receive the following benefits from a collaborative partnership with the school, the family and the community: higher grades and test scores, better attendance and homework completion, fewer placements in special education, more positive attitudes and behavior, higher graduation rates and greater enrollment in post secondary education. The gain for families includes: improved understanding of their child's development, improved ability to parent, improved ability to assist their children with school and learning, and improved relationships among all stakeholders.

Parents/families, school board members, school faculty representatives, and community members were involved in the development of a written Parent/Family Involvement Policy that has been adopted by the Dickson Public Schools Board of Education.

Parent and Family Engagement Meetings will be held annually as part of the Federal Programs Meeting for the purpose of planning, implementing, and evaluating the Parent and Family Engagement Policy. At this meeting all Title Programs will be discussed, as well as the Title I Plan for the LEA. Specifically, the district will review academic achievement and progress and will discuss evidence based strategies to improve.

Family Engagement Advisory Council
The Family Engagement Advisory Council members are listed below:

District Team:

Matt Krimmer, Director of Curriculum and Teaching; Federal Programs Director
Jennifer Mays-Krimmer, Behavioral Specialist; Communications Director
Janie Herriot, Board Member

Business/Community

Jamie Lang, Lighthouse Counseling Services; Parent

Committee:

Danesa Wilson, Parent/Teacher
Brittney Offield, Teacher
Zach Gadberry, Parent/Teacher
Amber Gadberry, Parent/Teacher
Aimee Garrett, Parent/Teacher
Jake Melton, Parent/Principal
David Gardner, Principal
Debby Custer, Principal
Angie Jones, Parent

SECTION I - GOALS

Open and two-way communication between families and the district and school both verbally and in writing using a variety of strategies and methods will be supported and increased.

Strategies:

1. Schoolwide Parent/Teacher Conferences will be held at least twice yearly to inform parents of their child's progress in school including academic performance and assistance with understanding their child's individual classroom grades and test results to address specific academic needs of their child.
    a. Parent/Teacher Conferences will be held at the end of the first nine-weeks and the end of the third nine-weeks for all the schools.
2. A "Parent University" will be held at the beginning of each school year, and the following information will be communicated to parents:
    - Purpose of the Family Engagement Initiative
    - Family Engagement School Board Policy
    - Title I Requirements
    - Assessment Results on all State Tests
    - NCLB Waiver – Accountability Standards

- Curriculum
- School-Parent Compact
- School Policies
- Teacher Information
- Parent Rights
- Future Family Engagement Activities

3. Each school will hold an annual Title I Meeting in which all parents of all students will be invited and encouraged to attend. Parents/families will be informed of their school's participation in the Title I Program, and the right of the parents/families to be involved. Parents will be informed of the following information:
    - Teacher/Parent/Student Compact
    - Current student assessment scores
    - Curricular information including any changes in the curriculum and assessment instructional strategies (Oklahoma Academic Standards)
    - Continue to develop and review the Title I Plan to build capacity to improve academic achievement through evidence based strategies.

4. A Student Handbook will be sent home at the beginning of each school year to inform parents of district and school policies for enrollment, attendance, homework, safety and discipline procedures, bus routes and bus behavior, Technology Acceptable Use Policy and Parents Educational Rights and Privacy Act. Parents are required to sign and return to the child's teacher the appropriate form attached to the front of the handbook stating that they have read and discussed the handbook with their child.

5. A School-Parent Compact, a requirement of the Title I Program will be jointly developed by the Family Engagement Advisory Council that outlines how parents, the school staff, and students will share the responsibility for improved student academic achievement and the means by which the school and parents will build and develop a partnership to help children achieve the State's high standards.

6. Teachers will send home in writing to families/parents classroom information including teacher information (phone number and email address), classroom rules and procedures, grading policy, etc. at the beginning of the school year. This information can also be found on the school and teacher websites.

7. Teachers will communicate with families/parents concerning their child's successes and/or problems on a regular basis through reports, notes, letters, phone calls, awards, etc.
    a. Report cards will be sent to parents at the end of each nine-week period in the elementary and high schools.
    b. A mid-nine-week report will be sent home at all school centers to make parents aware of student progress as well as allow parents the opportunity to request conferences and additional information to provide added supervision of student learning/homework in order to improve grades if needed.
    c. Teachers will document parent contacts and whether made by phone, note, home visit, etc. indicating the date and information discussed.
    d. Grades 3 and up have grades in Wengage which are updated regularly. Parents can access at any time.

8. School/classroom newsletters and notes will be written in students' native language and sent to parents/families on a regular basis to keep parents informed of school and classroom events and/or activities.

9. Parent/family surveys and checklists will be used to gain parent input and suggestions as to the quality of parent engagement activities in the school. A suggestion box will be set up in each school center as a means to receive suggestions from parents on how to better serve children. All suggestions are to be typed and submitted to the Director of Schools monthly and will be reviewed by the District Family Engagement Team to discuss ways to improve parent/family interaction.

10. A copy of the School Board Parent Involvement Policy and information related to programs, meetings, and activities will be placed in the Student Handbook and on the district website at www.dickson.k12.ok.ok.us.

11. Parents/families will be informed in the Dickson Student Handbook of their right to access their children's official school records. A Pre-K Handbook informs Pre-K parents' of requirements and guidelines.

12. Parents/families will be informed through various mediums of their right to access the Dickson Public School District Family Engagement Policy and curriculum information on the school or district website located at www.dickson.k12.ok.us. Curriculum information may be obtained from the Oklahoma Department of Education www.ok.gov/sde.

13. Teacher certification and qualifications including Highly Qualified information will be available for parent review or by addressing questions to the Director of Curriculum and Teaching. Parents were informed of this information through letters.

14. Menus will be published weekly monthly on the school website and app.

15. An “end of the year” ceremony will be conducted at each school center which includes special activities such as Awards Day, etc.

16. The School Messenger System is a parent/staff notification system to give parents/staff pertinent information such as school closure for inclement weather.

Family/Parents’ opportunities for involvement in classroom, school, and district activities will be increased.

1. Many activities will be provided at the district level and at individual schools to allow parents/families to be involved in their child’s school and learning:
    a. Parent Volunteer Program: All schools will encourage parents to volunteer in the school with activities such as reading with children, tutoring, designing bulletin boards, or clerical work. A log will be maintained documenting parent volunteers and the number of hours of parent/family volunteer time.
    b. Transition/Orientation activities will be developed at each school to assist students/parents/families in the transition between buildings.
    c. Parents will be given the opportunity to become involved in their child’s education by participating in the following activities and programs:
        • Father/Daughter Dance
        • Special Student Programs
        • Carnivals/Festivals
        • Veterans’ Day Programs
        • Costume Walks
        • Awards/Honors Day
        • Multiplication/Spelling Bees
        • Room Mothers/Fathers to help with classroom events such as parties, etc.
        • Scholars Bowl, both elementary and high school
        • G/T – Talented and Gifted Program
        • Eighth Grade Parent Night
        • Senior Night for Athletics
        • Sports Banquets

- Senior Awards Banquet
- Spring Art Exhibit
- Post-Secondary Financial Aid Meeting
- College Orientation Program

Parents/families will be given increased assistance by district/school staff to gain the knowledge and skills in parenting and fostering conditions to assist and support their children's learning and development at home.

1. Since parents are a child's first and most important teacher, they will be given parental support for their child's academic success in school.
    a. Parents will be invited to support their children through attending various school events including student programs, performances, assemblies, sports events, etc.
    b. A monthly event calendar will be maintained on the district website.
    c. Parents will be provided with curriculum information on the Oklahoma Academic Standards. The Oklahoma State Department website at ok.gov/sde has the standards listed under curriculum.
    d. Parents will be provided with pamphlets and brochures with suggestions for successful parenting skills.
    e. Parents will be encouraged to monitor and/or supervise homework and daily reading activities that reinforce or enrich their child's classroom learning and a list of selected books to read is provided.
    f. Parents will be encouraged to monitor their children's television viewing as well as their use of free time.
2. Parents/families participation in joint projects that involve children and teachers will be encouraged and supported.
    a. Annual Colonial Days in the Upper Elementary and Mini Society in the Lower Elementary encourages students and parents to work together on large projects.
    b. 4H and Boy/Girls Scouts gives parents and students an opportunity to work together on projects.
    c. The district will provide multiple opportunities for parents to develop their parenting and child-rearing skills to help their children succeed in school and life.

Parents/Families and community organizations will be provided numerous opportunities to share in decision-making and to become leaders in the advisory and advocacy roles in the schools including school review and steps for school improvement.

1. The district and schools will invite parents to participate as partners in decision-making activities.
    a. One or more parents from each representative school center were involved in the development of the District/School Family Engagement Plan, School Improvement Plan, NCLB Committee, etc.
    b. Each school site will establish a Parent/Family Advisory Committee to meet quarterly with minutes being recorded.

2. The District and Schools will collaborate with business and community organizations.
    a. The school and the Carter County Chamber of Commerce will continue to work together to secure GAPS funding in the future.
    b. Dickson will maintain its strong partnership with Lighthouse, LLC in referring students and parents for counseling services, as well as bringing in certified counselors to conduct SEL lessons.
    c. Dickson will continue its partnership with the Ardmore Homeless Shelter in using its first offender program as an alternative to long term suspensions.
    d. Citizens Bank provides numerous donations throughout the year for teacher wellness and appreciation.

SECTION II – COORDINATION, ASSISTANCE, AND SUPPORT

The School District will provide the coordination, technical assistance and support through direct participation of Central Office Staff and the Family Engagement Advisory Council to assist schools in planning and implementing effective Parent/Family Involvement activities.

1. The Central Office will provide technical assistance and support in helping schools in planning and implementing their School Parent and Family Involvement Plan.

    1. The Central Office staff provided technical assistance and support in helping the schools implement the annual “Parent University.” Central Office staff advertised the event in the news media, provided invitations and a sample agenda, and Central Office staff attended via Zoom.

    2. Principals attended a meeting at the Central Office to work on their School Parent/Family Involvement Plan. Each school’s Family Engagement Plan will be submitted to the Central Office.

III. EVALUATION

1. The Family Engagement Advisory Council will annually evaluate the content and effectiveness of the Family Engagement Program in the district and schools.

2. Family and Community feedback concerning the effectiveness will be received through multiple outlets in order to evaluate the effectiveness of the engagement program. Feedback will be accepted from our website, emails, suggestion boxes, and annually at our Family Engagement Meeting.

3. Documentation from district/school/family engagement activities such as a scrapbook including sign-ins with name and position, minutes of meetings, surveys, questionnaires, invitations, agendas, pictures, videos, newsletters, and news releases will be maintained at the district and at each school office.

4. The Family Engagement Advisory Council will identify and develop strategies to remove barriers that prevents parents from participating in district/school family engagement activities.
    a. Many of our parent/family members work and cannot attend during the school day.
        i. Provide more activities at night.
    b. Contact through text as opposed to voice.

The school district with input from the Family Engagement Advisory Council has provided parents the parent involvement policy and information about school programs, meetings, and activities.